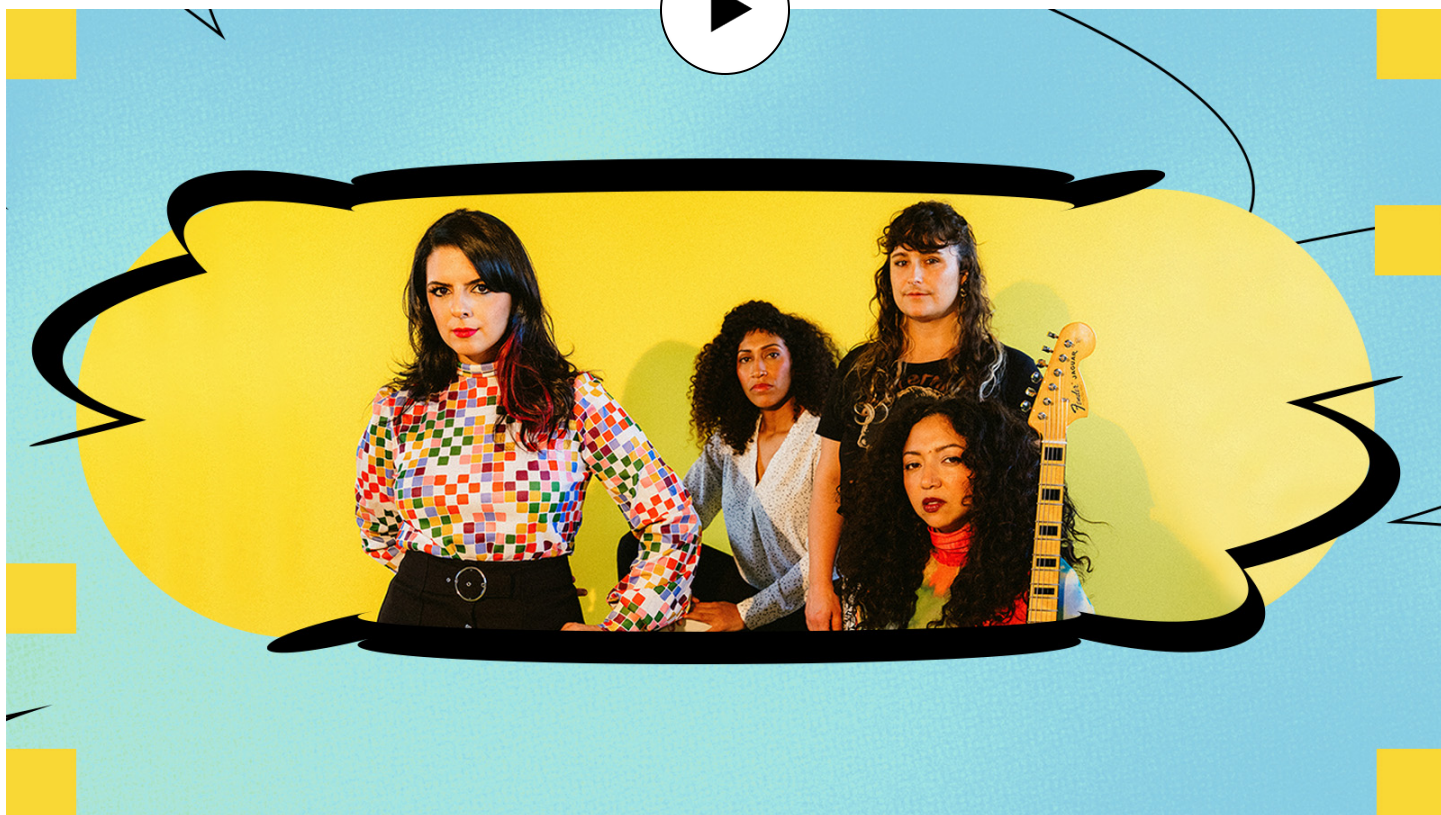




ESSENTIAL RELEASES

Essential Releases, May 24, 2024

By [Bandcamp Daily Staff](#) · May 24, 2024



What the *Bandcamp Daily* editors are listening to right now.

La Luz records have always existed at the intersection of the natural and the mystical—the place where the physical world starts to melt into something more abstract. That’s doubly true on *News of the Universe*, the group’s fourth—and arguably best—full-length. Written in the wake of frontwoman Shana Cleveland’s cancer diagnosis, the album’s songs straddle this world and the next, instilling Cleveland’s wonderfully fanciful lyrical style with new shadows. (The most striking of these is in album highlight “Dandelions,” where Cleveland observes, “Dandelions, little suns of the meadow/ How soon they’ll be turning into moons.”) The group’s beautifully baroque songwriting feels more expansive, too. La Luz has always drawn from the deep well of ‘60s psych pop, but here they achieve a kind of classical grandeur. Vocal melodies ascend the octave in half-steps, stopping off at every sharp and flat along the way, their winding trail enhancing Cleveland’s purposefully cryptic lyrics. “You can be a mystery if you really want to be,” she sings in the haunting “Good Luck With Your Secret.” That mystery is one of the things that has made La Luz one of the most consistently rewarding rock bands in independent music. *News of the Universe* is their most tantalizing puzzle yet.

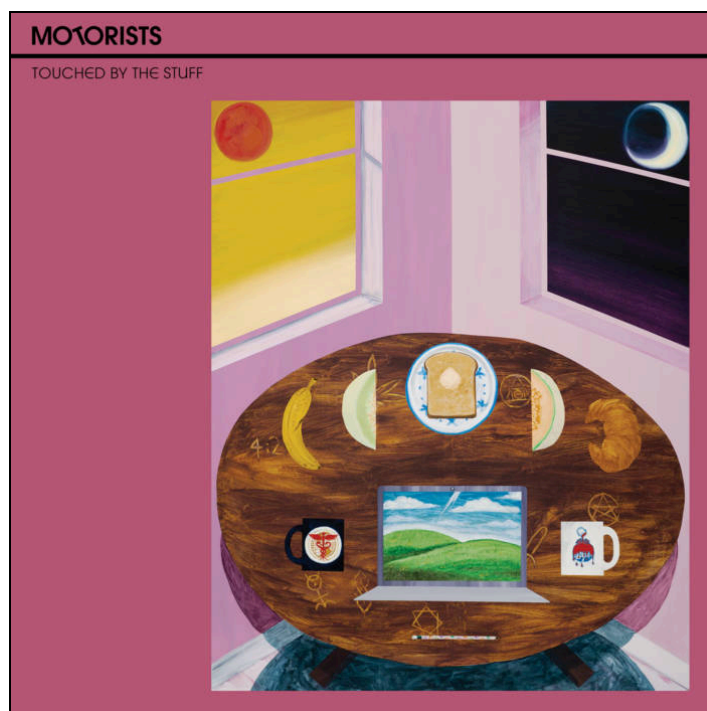
—J. Edward Keyes

Motorists
Touched By The Stuff



Bobo Integral
Madrid, Spain

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Touched by the Stuff by M...

BUY



WISHLIST

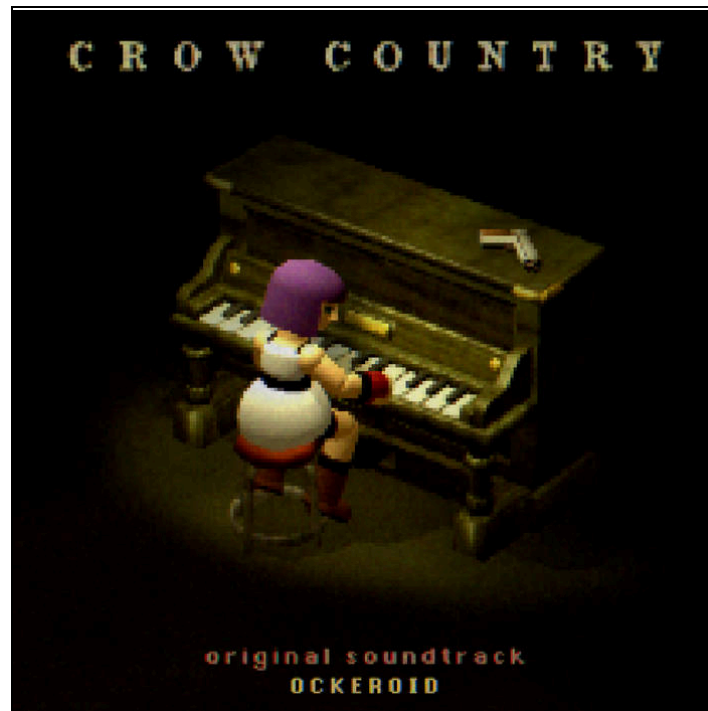
GO TO ALBUM

Well, this record is just nonstop hits, isn't it? The second LP from Toronto group Motorists is an unapologetic grab for the power pop crown, packing enough hooky hairpin twists and turns into its quick 35-minute running time to make all those New Jersey college rock bands from the early 80s proud. *Touched By The Stuff* excels in its sense of forward momentum and sheer sense of fun, even if the lyrics are a bit clunky to deserve vocals this foregrounded and reverb-free, if you care about such things (I do). But let's forgive 'em, music like this was never meant to make you think too hard, just drive slightly too fast.

–[Mariana Timony](#)

Ockeroid

Crow Country (Original Soundtrack)



Ockeroid
England, UK

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Crow Country (Original S...

BUY



WISHLIST

GO TO ALBUM

I know we've still got a week left in May, but with *Hades II*, *Animal Well*, *Berserk Boy*, *Hauntii*, and *Crow Country* all dropping over the past thirty days to unanimous, effusive praise, I'm just going to go ahead and call it: this was indie gaming's best month on record. The same goes for the soundtracks, which are strong across the board; still, in my view, the high score (pardon the pun) goes to Los Angeles composer [Ockeroid](#) and the eerie, yet playful ambient compositions they concocted